Sheltered beginnings

Vikram Sarabhai was the son of Ambalal and Sarla Devi Sarabhai, members of a wealthy industrialist family in Ahmedabad, Gujarat. His parents were very involved in their children's education, and set up a school exclusively for them with a unique curriculum. While his mother, aunts and sisters were active participants in the freedom movement, Sarabhai remained focused on academic pursuits. He was interested in science from an early age, and believed his most significant contribution to India would come from developing expertise in scientific study and research. He moved to Cambridge to study but was forced to return to India to continue his research when World War II broke out. He would return to Cambridge later to complete a doctoral degree.

"A PERSON WHO HAS IMBIBED THE WAYS OF SCIENCE INJECTS INTO A SITUATION A NEW WAY OF LOOKING AT IT…"

Man of many talents

Sarabhai was primarily a scientist, but his wide-ranging education meant that he was a man of diverse interests. He wanted to use his wealth to set up institutions for scientific research and study. He encouraged international collaboration and knowledge-sharing between scholars. The list of institutions he helped establish is long: the Physical Research Laboratory, the Ahmedabad Management Association (which later became the Indian Institute of Management, Ahmedabad), the Operations Research Group (India's first market research agency) and the National Institute of Design are just a few of them! He also took over the management of his family's businesses, and expanded into new areas during his lifetime.